

Building gazelles

A new infrastructure for weather and climate disaster data

Data Science for Environmental Policy

“Like the sea and like the air, the Internet is an arena for the powerful.”

Sundwall, Internet Power (2025)

The case

1980 to 2025: NOAA (National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, the US government weather and climate agency) kept a database of every US weather and climate disaster that cost more than \$1 billion

May 2025: the database was shut down

October 2025: its lead scientist restarted it at Climate Central, a nonprofit



TIME, 22 Oct 2025

The database

The database covered **403 disasters** since 1980, with about **\$2.9 trillion** in damage and around **17,000 deaths**

Who used it: climate scientists, policymakers and insurance companies

Who criticised it: some members of Congress said the methods were flawed, and some researchers questioned how transparent it was and whether the rising losses could be linked to climate change

The new version

Climate Central uses the same public and private data sources as NOAA, with some changes:

- events from \$100 million are now included
- wildfires are counted one by one, not by season
- AI tools are used to produce it

NOAA spent **millions of dollars** a year on the database. Climate Central has to raise that money itself



L.A. wildfires, January 2025. Photo: Agustin Paullier/AFP via Getty Images

Negotiation

Today we will negotiate the future of this database together. There are two councils, with one pair per role in each

Each council needs to agree on:

- who **hosts** the database
- who **pays** for it
- who **decides the method** (what counts as a disaster, how losses are measured)

How it works:

- each pair gets a role sheet with private information. You choose what to share
- you can make side deals and form coalitions
- not reaching a deal is also an outcome
- something may change halfway through

When you have a deal, write it on the board in three lines: host, payer, method

Guardians, commercial platforms, hybrids and gazelles

Jane Jacobs: **guardians** (states, NOAA) control and defend assets; **commercial** actors (firms, insurers) make and trade goods

Big tech is a **monstrous hybrid**: it trades *and* governs (platforms, cloud, attention). Sundwall's alternative: **gazelles**, small, nimble, Internet-native public institutions

*“Whoever gets to describe the status of the environment
... has the power over how the environment is regulated.”*

Sundwall, *Internet Power* (2025)

Roles

- (1) **Climate Central.** Has the expertise and a trusted name. Needs funding; the current money lasts about 18 months
- (2) **A reinsurance company.** Has loss data. Wants trusted public figures it can point to, but will not share its own data
- (3) **A cloud company (similar to AWS or Google).** Offers free hosting. Wants the data to be stored on its platform
- (4) **An AI weather company.** Can produce fast loss estimates. Wants the right to train its models on the data
- (5) **A city emergency manager.** Knows what disasters cost locally. Needs free local data to apply for funding

5 minutes to read your role sheet with your partner, then 15 minutes to negotiate

A new development

A future US administration offers to take the database back at NOAA

The condition is that the word "climate" is removed from all labels and descriptions

1. How are the two deals different, and why?
2. Is each deal closer to a guardian or a commercial arrangement? Is it a **gazelle**, or another **hybrid**?
3. Who now has the power to describe the state of the environment?

- Sundwall, J. (2025). Internet Power. Radiant Earth.
- Kluger, J. (2025). Trump Axed NOAA's Climate Disaster Data. This Group Brought It Back. TIME.
- Climate Central (2025). U.S. Billion-Dollar Weather and Climate Disasters.